



FALL LANDSCAPE

In the fall, the eastern flanks of the Southern Alps are relatively dry and sparsely vegetated, in contrast to the wet, forested side.

The Southern Alps

A high, steep mountain range running almost the whole length of New Zealand's South Island, with a pristine environment of glaciers, lakes, and forests



S. New Zealand

The Southern Alps are the most significant mountain range in New Zealand, extending for 310 miles (500 km) across the country's South Island, from southwest to northeast. Aoraki, or Mount Cook, the highest point in New Zealand, rises from the center of the range, peaking at 12,218 ft (3,724 m). Another 16 peaks exceed 10,000 ft (3,048 m) in height. Most of the rivers of South Island, including the longest, the Clutha River, flow from the Southern Alps.

Inching skyward

A boundary between two tectonic plates, called the Alpine Fault, runs to the west of the main line of the Southern Alps. It is of great significance to the mountains' origins and continuing uplift (see panel, left). The Southern Alps are continuing to rise, at a

rate of up to fractions of an inch annually, but are also being eroded at an equally fast rate, aided by the sheer steepness of the mountains, high rainfall on the western slopes, and the presence of several glaciers. Due to the high rainfall—which can be up to 390 in (10,000 mm) a year—the western slopes of the Alps are covered in temperate rain forest up to a height of about 3,300 ft (1,000 m). This leads to the unusual appearance of glaciers terminating a short distance away from lush rain forest. The eastern slopes are much drier and contain several large glacial lakes, such as Lake Tekapo and Lake Pukaki, which are both a brilliant powder blue color. Endemic birds in the region include the kea, the rare and flightless southern brown kiwi, and the New Zealand rock wren.

▽ CLEVER BIRD

The kea, the world's only alpine parrot, is well known for its curiosity and intelligence, including an ability to use tools and solve logical puzzles. It is found only in the Southern Alps.



The **Southern Alps** were **so-named** because of their **resemblance** to the **European Alps**